DRUGS · NASAL PREPARATIONS

Sodium cromoglicate

Sodium cromoglicate stabilises mast cells and prevents them releasing histamine and other mediators. It is safe in children and pregnancy but works only when used before exposure and several times a day. In ENT it is now a minor drug: a preventive spray for predictable allergen exposure and an eye drop for allergic conjunctivitis.

1 CHAPTER ONE At a glance

The drug on one page.

1.1 Summary

SODIUM CROMOGLICATE

	SUMMARY
Class	Mast-cell stabiliser (cromone)
How it works	Inhibits mast-cell degranulation, possibly through chloride channel effects
ENT uses	Prophylaxis of seasonal or exposure-related allergic rhinitis (pollen, animals); allergic conjunctivitis; patients wishing to avoid steroids, especially in pregnancy and children
Dose	Nasal spray 4%: 1 spray into each nostril two to four times daily (up to six times); eye drops 2%: 1 to 2 drops four times daily
Pregnancy	Considered safe

2 CHAPTER TWO Using it in ENT

Indications.

2.1 Place in treatment

Less effective than nasal steroids; useful for short, predictable exposures when started a week before the season or taken shortly before contact. It has no effect on symptoms once they have started.

3 CHAPTER THREE Safety

What goes wrong.

3.1 Adverse effects

Local irritation, transient sneezing; very rarely bronchospasm.

4 CHAPTER FOUR For the examination

What the examiner wants to hear.

4.1 Viva essentials

WHAT THE EXAMINER IS LOOKING FOR

- Mechanism and why it is preventive only.
- Where it fits (pregnancy, children, predictable exposure).

4.2 Common pitfalls

COMMON PITFALLS

- Using cromoglicate to relieve established symptoms.

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